



You can bet your last rupee that the multi-touchscreen will be copied by just about every hardware vendor out there

You've seen the movie, or have picked up the scene via osmosis; it's the geek interface zeitgeist—Tom Cruise flicking through files in *Minority Report*, his fingers are glowing, as part of the interface he is wearing gloves, and he is directly interacting with a hologram image of computer data: flick, flick, “these are not the files I want!”, flick, flick... This nature of interactivity might not be for the weak of arms, or the lazy, but as the Wii gaming console has recently shown, any interface that directly translates user input to screen activity is a good interface. So will we see a *Minority Report* “monitor + glove” combo anytime soon? Surprise: interfaces such as these have already been made and tested in labs around the world. In fact, the interface showcased in the movie was inspired by a project incubated in Microsoft's UI Labs!

Microsoft in particular has been trying unsuccessfully to push two types of interfaces at us. One of them is the Tablet PC way of interaction—pen inputs and handwriting recognition. We think this one hasn't been widely accepted due to the clumsy nature of Tablet PC hardware. Once Tablet PCs become small enough

Input Devices

Where is the ANY key?

and thin enough—in other words less like laptops and more notebooks—the interface may do better. “May,” because there will always be people who hate writing on screen as an input method. The other interface is that of voice and being able to dictate and communicate directly with a computer. Here too, the problem is two-fold: the software is not yet there, and not a lot of people are too keen on dictating to a PC.

So what could be a universal solution to the problem? A direct data dump from the brain to a computer? I hope not, unless the output is supposed to be an incoherent ramble. We can't imagine a unique solution to our input problem of today, but the question then becomes—is there anything wrong with the way we input data today?

While you can't imagine life without keyboard and mouse, you also can't imagine any other input device taking their place—or even complementing them. Well, maybe a joypad if you are a gamer, or a steering wheel if you are *really* into racing games. What else? Gesture-based computing? Multi-touch interfaces? Mouse and keyboard? Oh yes!

Gaming peripherals will hugely benefit now that Microsoft has decided that Xbox 360 peripherals may play nicely with the PC. You can thus buy a small adapter and a receiving station that will allow you to play games on your PC using the Xbox 360 controller. Also possible is the use of steering wheels on the PC which *would* have otherwise have been relegated to single duty on the Xbox 360. This blurring between the platforms will certainly help reduce costs for us consumers.

Microsoft is also keen on voice communication with

the PC. So much so that Vista comes with voice recognition built in—you can therefore dictate to your word processor or talk dirty to your Web browser, right out of the Vista box. Vista also extends the mouse functions to a digital tablet—if you are an artist and use the Wacom tablet or something similar, chances are that Vista natively supports the pen as an input device; the Ultimate variant of Vista comes with Tablet PC software, which allows handwriting recognition and pen-based gesture navigation.

The coolest aspect of the iPhone is its use of a multi-touch interface. A multi-touchscreen allows multiple inputs. What this means is that the screen can simultaneously listen for, and understand, more than one input point, as opposed to a single point of interaction, as is generally the norm with PDAs and their ilk. This opens up avenues for some funky gesture-based user-device interaction. One iPhone demo showcased the user being able to “pinch” the screen in order to zoom out of a photo. You can bet your last rupee that this interface will be copied by just about every hardware vendor on the face of Earth—brace yourself as multi-touch hits everything from cell phones to microwave ovens!

Finally, there is always the keyboard and the mouse. We hope to see rechargeable batteries marrying wireless keyboards, and please lose those ridiculous multimedia and system keys! We also wouldn't mind seeing some software widgets on our keyboards—so get SideShow to the keyboard, please.

We can't imagine an evolution of the mouse, though... perhaps it could sing to us? Or glow hypnotically? All devices could use some glow—make it happen!

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